

that person altogether. So if people are no longer doing that fun “stop ‘n’ chat” in the hall, or the coffee room empties when you arrive, then guess what—you may be a marked man or woman.

4. Did your last performance review read like a train wreck?

Most of the time, a performance review is a whole bunch of niceties. The boss really doesn’t want to say anything *too* good, because everyone has room for improvement. But generally, they praise within reason and avoid anything too negative. So if your review paints you as a stupid version of Homer Simpson with less talent than a Backstreet Boy, well, that tap on the shoulder is coming.

5. Has your company recently been sold or merged?

This is rarely good news for about 90% of the staff. Sure, management is fine. After all, they negotiated the deal. But whether you were sold or merged, the outcome is the same . . . changes will be made across the board. A merger means duplication of many jobs. Duplication = redundancy. Being sold means new management, and they always have new plans for the company. New plans that include

cutbacks and layoffs. Basically, watch your back if there’s a new name on the front door.

6. Are you being given impossible jobs with no chance of success?

This one is underhanded, which is why it’s so popular. The company may need a big reason to give you the boot, especially if you’ve done everything right and are the life and soul of your department. Enter the impossible task. “Ahh, Wilkins, we need you to expand our new line of warm, alcohol-free beers to construction workers.” “Johnson, how’s that line of umbrellas doing in the new LA store?” You get the picture. If you’ve been given a thankless task, at least be thankful for the blatant tip-off that you’re about to be let go.

7. Do you now have less responsibility than the intern?

Ouch. Being stripped of your responsibilities is a surefire sign that there’s something unpleasant on the horizon. After all, you don’t fire someone who’s got a ton of important work to do, with loads of people underneath him/her. So, over time the poor sucker in management’s sights will be given a